THE GCC PEOPLE PULSE

Q2 2026

The latest insights into the word on work

EMPLOYEE EXPERIENCE EXCHANGE

Ipsos

ABOUT THIS REPORT

EXE: Employee Experience Exchange and Ipsos are launching the GCC People Pulse: Word on Work - the region's first dedicated monthly workforce sentiment tracker.

The GCC is navigating unprecedented change: such as vision 2030, AI disruption, geopolitical instability, evolving labour markets. Yet most organisations are still guessing what their people think. The GCC People Pulse changes that.

Discover what workers truly think, feel, and experience at work. Not hopes. Not assumptions. Real insight from real conversations.

Monthly data. Quarterly reports. Rigorous methodology. Regionally-specific insights that reflect the real complexity of GCC workforces - their diversity, their challenges, their opportunities.

Read on to discover what the data reveals.

REAL DATA.
REAL PEOPLE.
REAL CHANGE.

METHODOLOGY

WAVE 1: Q2 2026

The GCC People Pulse is a monthly workforce sentiment tracker conducted by EXE: Employee Experience Exchange, in partnership with Ipsos. Data was collected from a representative sample of 1,500 employees across the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, and Qatar via online survey.

Respondents were adults in full or part-time employment at the time of fieldwork. Results are reported at the GCC level and broken down by country, age, gender, and nationality where base sizes allow. The survey covered 11 questions across five themes: advocacy, confidence, wellbeing, inclusion, and AI.

1	I would recommend my organisation as a great place to work
2	Leaders in my organisation do what they say they will
3	I feel confident about the future direction of my organisation
4	In recent months, I have felt under constant strain at work
5	I feel able to be myself at my organisation
6	My organisation demonstrates visible commitment to the country's nationalisation agenda
7	When changes are planned at my organisation, I feel involved and am prepared for the change
8	I plan to stay working for my employer for the next three or more years
9	My organisation encourages open and honest feedback
10	I believe that AI will make my organisation more competitive
11	I am concerned about the impact of AI on my job security

Respondent demographic breakdown:

COUNTRY

- **KSA** = 40%
- **UAE** = 50%
- **Qatar** = 13%
- **Kuwait** = 7%

AGE

- **18-34** = 50%
- **35-49** = 43%
- **50+** = 6%

NATIONALITY

- **Local** = 42%
- **Arab expat** = 26%
- **Asian** = 26%
- **Western/other** = 6%

GENDER

- **Female** = 39%
- **Male** = 61%

KEY FINDINGS

1

PEOPLE ARE THRIVING ON PAPER. YET THEY'RE BURNING OUT IN PRACTICE.

81% of GCC employees would recommend their organisation as a great place to work. But behind that number, 54% report feeling under constant strain at work in recent months - a whopping 17 points above the global average.

High advocacy and high burnout are coexisting. That's not sustainable. The organisations that act on wellbeing now will protect the advocacy scores they're proud of later.

2

CONFIDENCE ISN'T A SOFT METRIC. IT'S YOUR BIGGEST DRIVER OF ADVOCACY.

Employees who are confident in their organisation's future are nearly twice as likely to recommend it to others - 93% advocacy versus 42% - than those who aren't. With 77% of GCC employees currently feeling confident in that future, 22 points above the global benchmark, the foundation is strong.

But Kuwait, Qatar, and older employees lag behind. Clear communication and visible leadership are what close that gap.

3

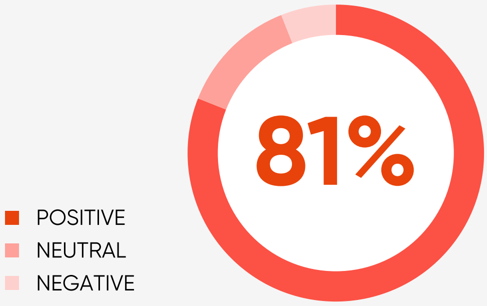
PEOPLE BELIEVE IN AI. THEY JUST DON'T FEEL READY FOR IT.

73% of GCC employees believe AI will make their organisation more competitive. But nearly half (49%) are concerned about what it means for their job security. Opportunity and anxiety are both real, and growing in parallel.

Wider research suggests that organisations aren't training enough - recent Ipsos/Google research showed only 14% of US employees have received AI training. Companies that invest in training now won't just upskill their workforce, they'll shift the narrative from threat to capability.

EMPLOYEES VOUCH FOR YOU. BUT ADVOCACY ALONE WON'T KEEP THEM.

81% would recommend you. Yet 24% plan to leave within two years. What's really going on?



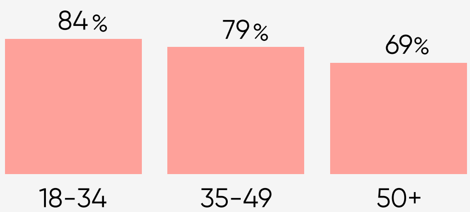
of employees would recommend their organisation as a great place to work.

- **9pts**. above global average
- **1pt**. above MENA average

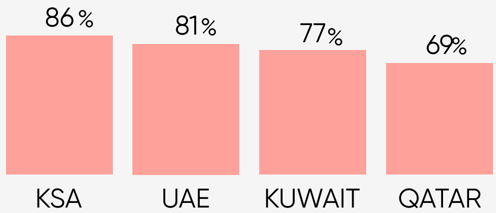
What this means

Recommendation is high across the GCC, comfortably outstripping the global benchmark, with advocacy strongest among younger employees and in KSA and UAE. However, there is an almost 20-point spread geographically, with Qatar-based employees notably less likely to recommend.

BY AGE



BY COUNTRY



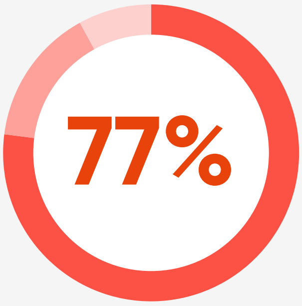
Except where otherwise stated, base for all data is : n=1500

Why this matters

An 'active' measure of employee engagement, research suggests advocacy is more strongly linked to commercial and company performance than more passive sentiment such as pride. It also plays a significant role in an organisation's talent agenda — employees are your most credible recruiters, bringing your employer brand and value proposition to life. Where advocacy is low, attracting talent becomes more challenging, and retaining it even more so.

CONFIDENCE UNLOCKS ADVOCACY. CLARITY SUSTAINS IT.

Your people trust your direction - confidence is 22 points ahead of global benchmarks. Communication keeps it alive.



POSITIVE
NEUTRAL
NEGATIVE

of employees feel confident in the future direction of their organisation

▲ **22pts**. above global average

▼ **1pt**. below MENA average

What this means

Employees across the GCC show much higher confidence in their organisations than global benchmarks, though confidence is lower in Kuwait, Qatar, and among older employees. This strongly influences their likelihood to recommend their employer.

Advocacy when employees are NOT confident in the future direction of their org.

42%

N=349

Advocacy when employees ARE confident in the future direction of their org.

93%

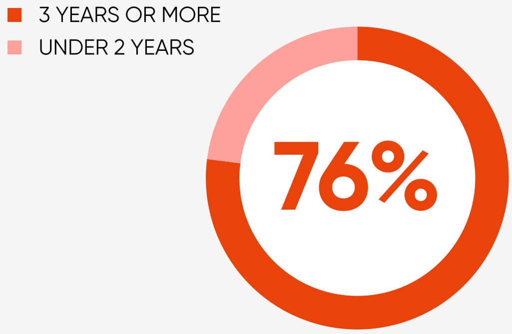
N=1151

Why this matters

The relationship between confidence and advocacy is one of the most consequential dynamics in our data. People who believe in the future direction of their organisation are significantly more likely to recommend it to others, making confidence a direct driver of brand. This places clear strategic direction, effective leadership and honest communication at the heart of employee experience.

ATTRITION ALERT: 24% ARE ALREADY LOOKING FOR AN EXIT.

GCC employees are more likely to want to leave near-term than wider global or MENA populations.



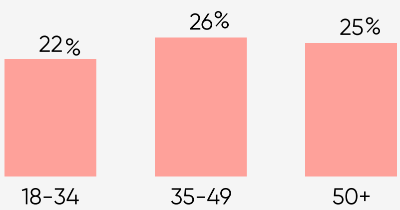
of employees plan to stay working for their current employer for three years or more

- **1pt**. below global average
- **6pts.** below MENA average

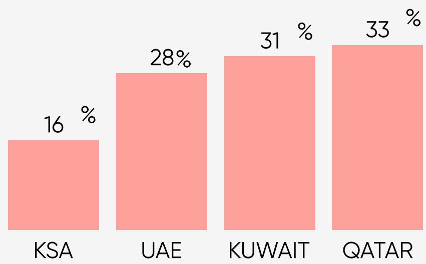
What this means

Around three-quarters of employees intend to stay with their organisation for at least three years, below MENA and global benchmarks. Attrition risk is higher among middle-aged employees and in Kuwait and Qatar, while only 16% of employees in Saudi Arabia expect to leave within two years.

BY AGE



BY COUNTRY



Why this matters

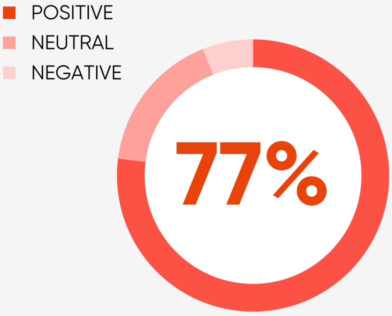
Intent to stay is highly predictive of actual employee behaviour, so elevated attrition risk across the GCC warrants attention. Higher intent to leave among middle-aged employees is particularly concerning. These people often occupy mid-tier management roles where a significant amount of organisational knowledge and capability resides. Losing this population carries an organisational and commercial cost.

33%

of employees in Qatar intend to leave their organisation in the next two years

POSITIVE MOMENTUM ON NATIONALISATION, BUT SENSE OF BELONGING IS LAGGING

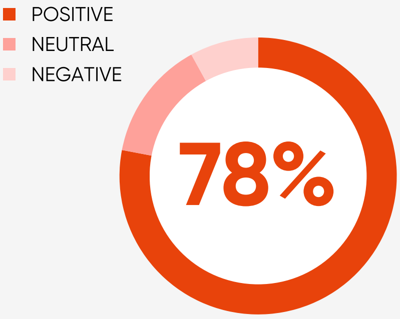
78% feel they can be themselves and 77% see organisational commitment to nationalisation.



believe their organisation demonstrates visible commitment to the country's nationalisation agenda

Rising to **85%** for GCC Nationals

However, belonging remains one of the few areas where GCC employees trail behind both MENA and global peers.



of employees feel they can be themselves at their organisation

- **3pts** below global average
- **6pts.** below MENA average

Rising to **84%** for GCC Nationals

Why this matters

Nationalisation is critical to the long-term sustainability of GCC economies, so it is positive to see organisations' efforts are landing effectively with the very population they are intended to impact: GCC Nationals.

Sense of belonging in non-national populations is slightly lower than elsewhere in the world. Organisations must ensure this very necessary focus comes as part of wider efforts to ensure inclusion and opportunity for all employees.

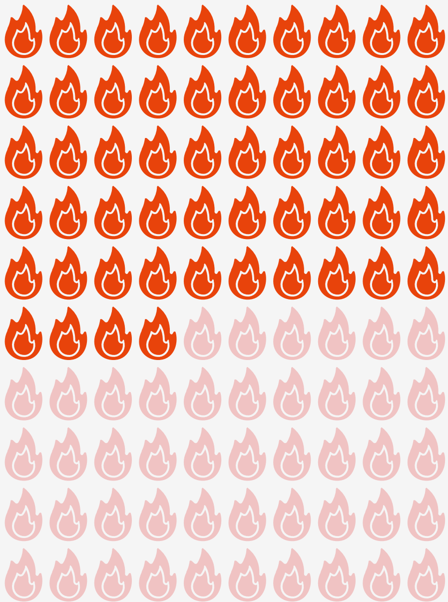
Only

18%

of GCC-based employees report that they do not feel under constant strain at work.

OVER HALF OF GCC EMPLOYEES REPORT CONSTANT STRAIN AT WORK

54% say they've been under constant strain in recent months - 17 points above global benchmarks. And it's hitting younger and mid-career talent hardest.



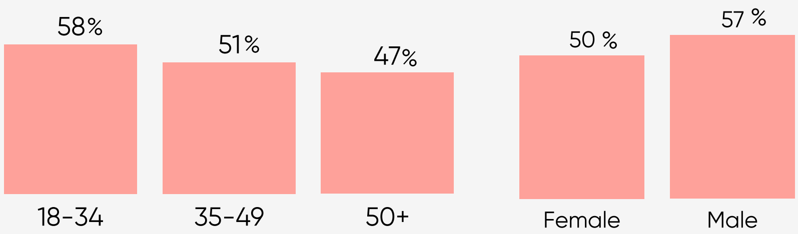
54%

of employees report feeling under constant strain at work

- **17pts.** above global average
- **5pts.** below 2024 results *(KSA/UAE)*

BY AGE

BY GENDER



Why this matters

Strain is the human cost of stress and pressure, manifesting as anxiety, exhaustion and , eventually, burnout. While strain does not directly drive attrition, employees who stay are not necessarily performing, contributing or thriving. Wider research confirms that strain has a profound negative effect on decision making, team dynamics and individual performance, making it a risk that cannot be overlooked.

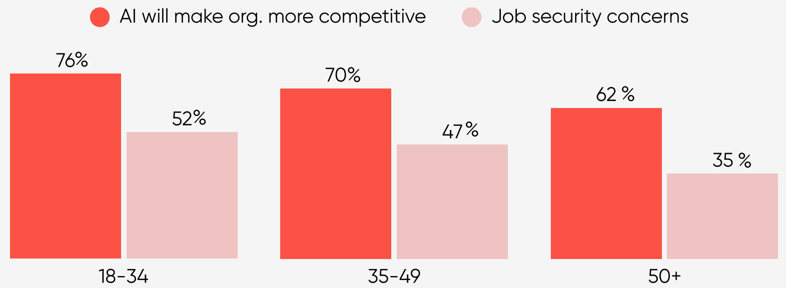
EMPLOYEES SEE THE POTENTIAL OF AI. FEAR HINDERS ADOPTION.

73% see a competitive advantage from the introduction of AI. 49% worry about its impact on their job security. Only 14% have been trained. The gap is yours to close.

73% of employees believe AI will make their organisation more competitive

49% of employees are concerned about the impact of AI on their job security

BY AGE

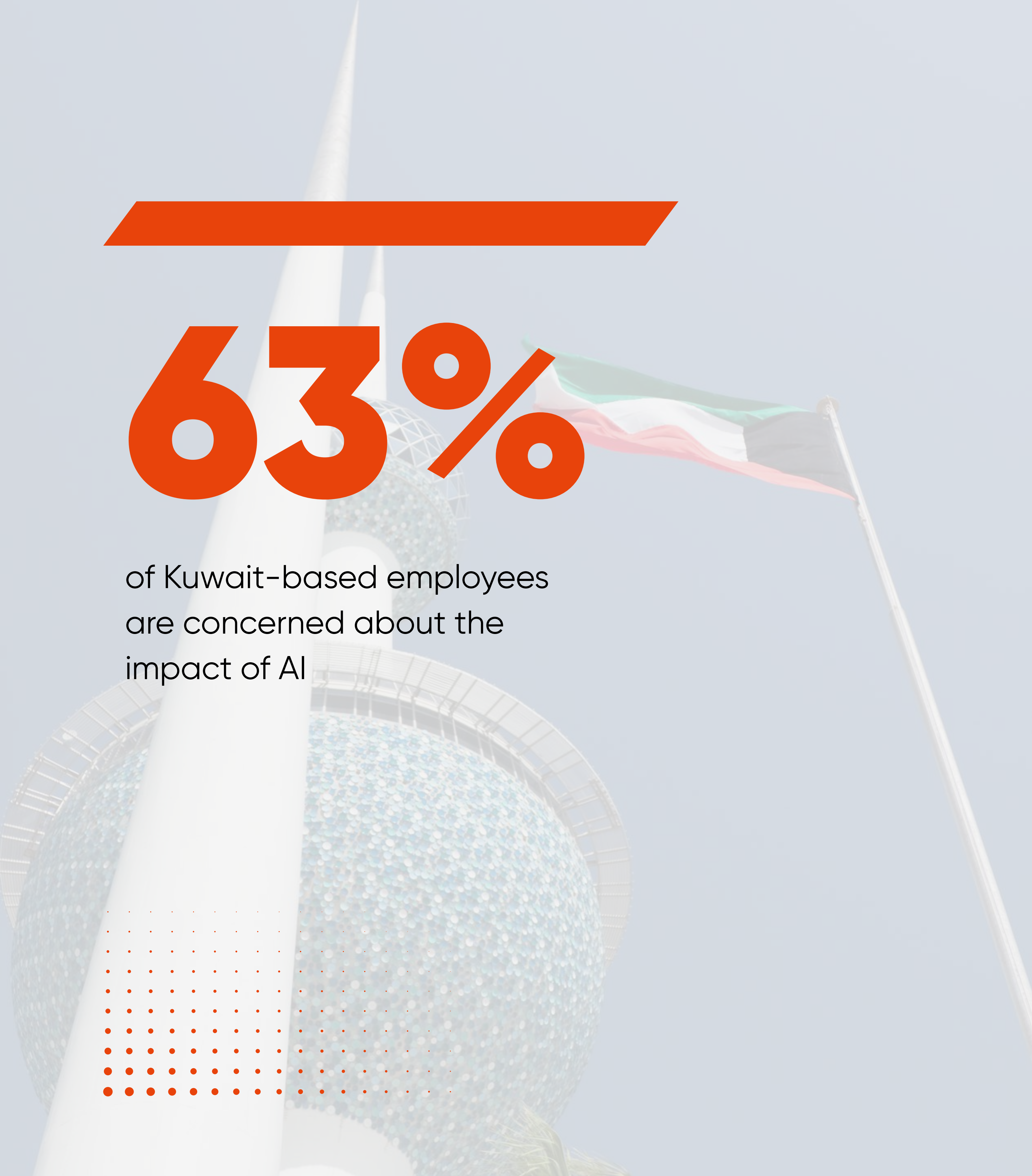


What this means

Nearly three quarters of employees see AI as a critical business enabler, but around half are concerned about job security, particularly in markets such as Qatar. Younger employees are more balanced, recognising both the opportunities and risks.

The variable sentiment in GCC People Pulse data reflects wider opinions on AI. Ipsos' latest Global AI Monitor suggests global workers see AI as having a significant impact - 62% of workers think AI will change how they do their job in the next five years. But this impact may not be wholly positive. Global Ipsos/Google research shows an even 50/50 split between workers thinking AI will create new jobs vs. eliminate them.

Some of this fear may be down to limited training. US Ipsos/Google research found only 14% of workers have received AI training from their employer and, while 40% use AI, only 5% are considered fluent.

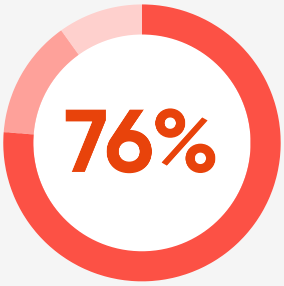


63%

of Kuwait-based employees are concerned about the impact of AI

EMPLOYEE VOICE LINKED TO HIGHER LEVELS OF ADVOCACY AND INTENT TO STAY.

Advocacy is twice as high and intent to stay is significantly greater when employees feel their organisation genuinely welcomes and acts on their feedback.

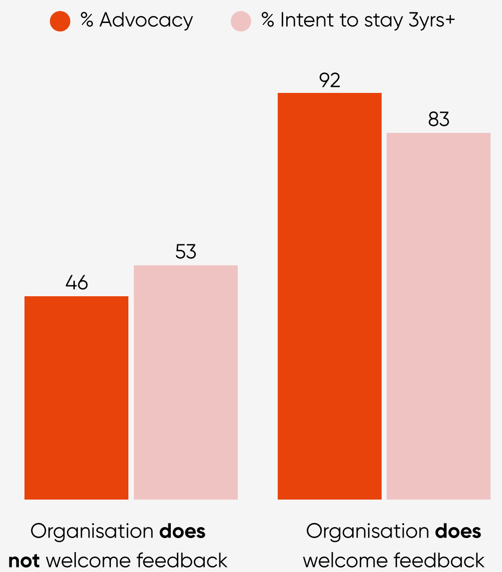


of employees believe their organisation encourages open and honest feedback

81% = KSA 77% = UAE 67% = KUWAIT 64% = QATAR

- POSITIVE
- NEUTRAL
- NEGATIVE

Employee advocacy is x2 higher when employees feel their organisation welcomes feedback.



What this means

Employee voice is closely linked to stronger employee loyalty. Employees who feel their organisation welcomes feedback are twice as likely to advocate for their employer (92% vs 46%) and significantly more likely to intend to stay (83% vs 53%). While 76% say their organisation encourages open and honest feedback, this falls to 64% in Qatar.

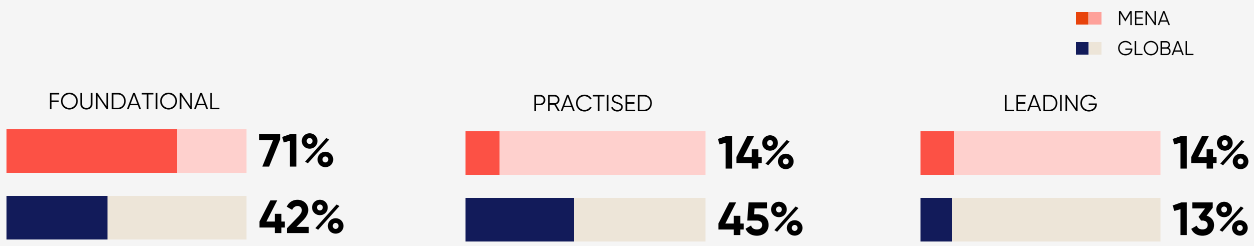
Why this matters

Seeking feedback is not a nice to have, it is a critical enabler of performance. Employees who feel heard, and crucially who see action taken as a result, become genuinely invested in the organisation's success, and that commitment shows up directly in higher advocacy and intent to stay. Beyond engagement, a listening culture is also a commercial asset; employees on the front line hold invaluable insight into what is getting in the way of a better customer experience, and how to fix it.

FOUNDATIONAL EX PROGRAMMES ARE THE NORM IN MENA.

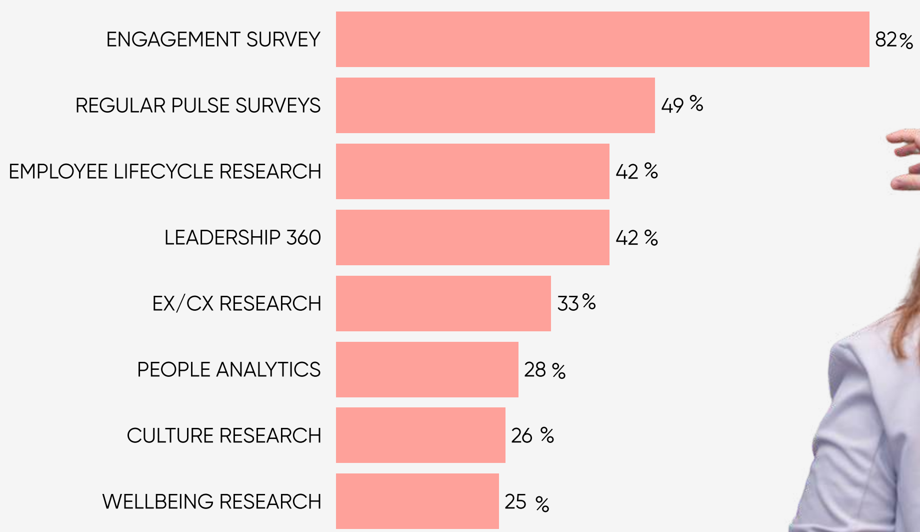
Ipsos research shows a clear listening gap, with most MENA organisations reporting only foundational EX programmes and global EX maturity still lagging.

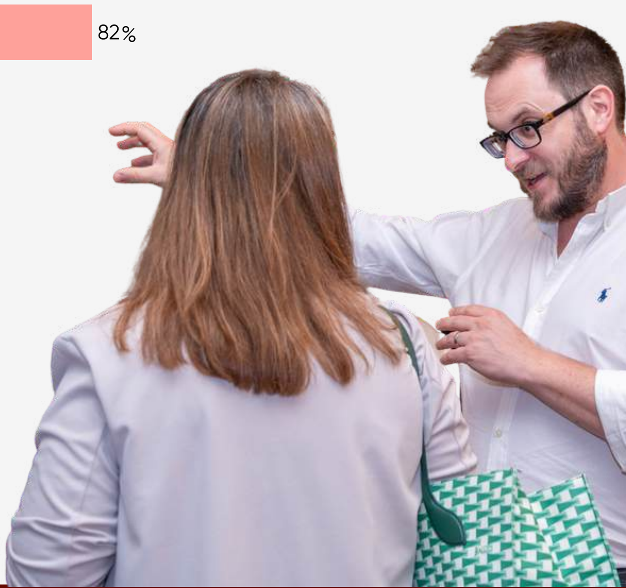
Which of these descriptions best describes the current state of your EX programme?



What kind of research does your organisation undertake?

GLOBAL DATA





Why this matters

With 71% of MENA organisations rating their EX programmes as foundational, there is a clear gap between employee expectations around being heard and the capability organisations have to meet them. Annual surveys remain the dominant listening tool, yet point-in-time measurement misses the shifts in sentiment and intent that occur throughout the year. With only 13% of MENA practitioners utilising people analytics, organisations risk making significant people decisions without the insight needed to make informed choices.

LOOKING FORWARD

What you can do to stand out from the crowd

What you can do

RIGHT NOW

- Examine your own country-level data. If your results vary like these findings, activity may need to be market-specific, not one size fits all.
- Launch role-specific AI training, show employees how it augments their work, not replaces it.
- Close the feedback loop publicly, tell people what changed and why.

NEXT QUARTER

- Invest in mid-career employees; they hold the most knowledge and carry the highest attrition risk.
- Review nationalisation programmes to ensure they continue to build inclusion, not seed the potential for division.
- Take stock of your EX maturity; are you listening to the right people, in the right ways, to drive the right outcomes?
- Shift from annual surveys to continuous listening, or adding culture, wellbeing and AI readiness to your EX programme.

FOR YOUR LEADERSHIP

- Reinforce strategic direction consistently - 77% of employees are confident, 22pts above global. Protect it.
- Be visible - employees who trust leadership direction are twice as likely to advocate for the organisation.
- Make listening feel real, not performative. Trust is built through action, not intention.

BEHIND THIS REPORT

EXE, Employee Experience Exchange, is a UAE-based community and consultancy on a mission to transform society by transforming work. We believe workplaces sit at the centre of our lives - and that when people thrive at work, communities and economies thrive too. We audit, advise and partner with organisations to create employee experiences that match their ambition. We bring together HR, internal communications, culture and leadership professionals across the GCC who share a belief that work can and should be better.

Ipsos is one of the largest market research and polling companies globally, operating in 90 markets and employing 19,000 people. Our passionately curious research professionals, analysts and scientists have built unique multi-specialist capabilities that provide true understanding and powerful insights into the actions, opinions and motivations of citizens, consumers, patients, customers or employees. Our 75 business solutions are based on primary data from our surveys, social media monitoring, and qualitative techniques.

DON'T MISS OUT!

The GCC People Pulse: Word on Work is updated every quarter

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Got questions?
Get in touch at hello@weareexe.com